Ranganathittu Bird Sanctuary, Karnataka

This string of riverine islets in the fast-flowing Kaveri River near Mysuru was declared a protected area in 1940 at the insistence of Dr Sálim Ali. With broadleaf forests, riverine reed beds and exposed rocks, the islands form an important breeding ground for birds such as the Painted Stork, Indian River Tern, Great Thick-knee, Spot-billed Pelican and Streak-throated Swallow.



Spot-billed Pelican

Nal Sarovar Bird Sanctuary, Gujarat

Gujarat's largest wetland bird sanctuary, Nal Sarovar, is located just an hour's drive west of Ahmedabad. Over 200 bird species have been recorded here in appreciable numbers. Birders make a beeline in winter to see the Greater Flamingo, Indian Skimmer, Pied Avocet and Common Crane.

Black-headed Bunting



INDIA PICTURE

Sundarbans National Park, West Bengal

This protected area comprising the dense mangrove forests of the Gangetic delta is spread across 54 islands crisscrossed by channels and distributaries. While best known as the home of the majestic Royal Bengal Tiger, it is a unique ecosystem that shelters birds like the Masked Finfoot and Mangrove Pitta. It is also the best place to see diverse kingfisher species, including the Brown-winged Kingfisher, Black-capped Kingfisher and Collared Kingfisher.



INDIA PICTURE

Ruddy Kingfisher

While birding brings us great enjoyment, it is important to realise that birds face various threats from human activity. The State of India's Birds, 2023, a report released recently by a consortium of conservation bodies, stresses the sobering fact that 39 per cent of our birds have shown a sharp decline in numbers caused by land-use change, urbanisation, ecosystem degradation, monocultures, disease, infrastructure development, pet trade, hunting, pollution and climate change.

As birding brings increased footfalls to protected areas, the pressure is on operators to conduct tourism activities in a sustainable manner. Responsible birders take the initiative to enjoy their hobby with the least possible disturbance to birds and their environment, while following ethical practices such as avoiding nest photography, shunning call playback to lure birds and taking back their garbage. Before you narrow down on your bird guide, make sure that they check all the boxes for ethical and responsible tourism.

Happy birding! ■